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Governance by numbers 2.0: policy brokerage as an instrument of global governance in the era of information overload

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ABSTRACT

The article investigates how and when the two first movers in knowledge-based regulation – the OECD and the World Bank – developed policy brokerage as an instrument of global governance in the education sector. We also examine how their target clientele – national governments – responds to this instrument. Given the surplus of research evidence in today's digital economy, intergovernmental organisations have the challenge of standing out as trusted and credible knowledge brokers in a crowded space. The authors make the case for a comparative research programme – tentatively labeled 'Governance by Numbers 2.0' – that is informed by a multidisciplinary (history, political science, interdisciplinary policy studies) interpretive framework and that advances a transnational, relational method of inquiry which draws attention to the global/national nexus.

KEYWORDS

Comparative education
policy; global governance;
policy transfer;
intergovernmental
organisations

关键词

比较教育政策; 全球治理;
政策转移; 政府间组织

数字治理 2.0：信息过量时代作为全球治理工具的政策中介

摘要

本文研究用知识进行监管的两个先行者——经合组织和世界银行——是如何以及何时将政策中介发展成为教育领域全球治理的工具。我们也研究了他们的目标客户，即各国政府，对这一工具的应对。在当今的数字经济时代，研究证据往往过剩，政府间组织面临的挑战是在纷繁杂乱的信息空间中脱颖而出，成为可靠可信的知识经纪人。对此，作者提出一个比较研究计划，暂将其命名为‘数字治理 2.0’，该计划基于多学科（历史、政治学、跨学科政策研究）的解释框架，并提出一种跨国的、相关性的调查方法，吸引人们关注全球/国家的关联。

In this article, we investigate how and when the two first movers in knowledge-based regulation – the OECD and the World Bank – developed policy brokerage as one of their primary instruments of global governance in the education sector.¹ The 'surplus

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of evidence' and the 'marketplace of ideas' (Lubienski 2019, 70), as well as the proliferation of information silos (Malin and Lubienski 2022), have generated a renewed opportunity for intermediaries to bridge knowledge producers and knowledge users, or science and politics.

Intellectual endeavours that seek to understand the uneasy relationship between science and politics abound. The study of knowledge brokerage dates back to Caplan's (1979) two-communities theory. As Mackillop, Downe, and Quarmby (2019) pointed out, the polarisation between the two communities – science and politics – sometimes uncritically suggests a differentiation between truth (produced by science) and action (taken by politics). The individuals or organisations dedicated to transferring, translating, or 'pushing' research, truth, or facts onto political decision-makers – that is, bridging the two communities – are called brokers, intermediaries, or boundary spanners. Of course, the differentiation between knowledge brokerage and policy brokerage is fluid when the same organisation brokers knowledge it previously produced in-house or, even more blatantly, produces, brokers, *and* funds its projects with recourse to scientific rationality. Therefore, we propose to use the term 'policy brokerage' rather than the more neutral term 'knowledge brokerage' throughout this article.

We also examine how their target clientele – national governments – responds to these instruments. This complex research enterprise requires a multidisciplinary (history, political science, sociology) and transnational, relational interpretive framework that draws attention to the global/national nexus. By now, all Big Five in the education sector (Global Partnership for Education, OECD, UNESCO, UNICEF, World Bank) exert 'soft power by hard facts' (Niemann and Martens 2018). Combined, the Big Five and their funders (member states, businesses, private foundations) constitute a 'global education governing complex' (Ydesen 2019) that weaponises a particular kind of knowledge – quantifiable, comparable, and standardizable – in order to hold governments accountable for the achievement of international goals and targets.

1. Policy brokerage under conditions of ambiguity, contestation, and uncertainty

Over the last few years, a vast body of studies have emerged that attempt to understand the rise of knowledge brokers in public policy (see Mackillop, Downe, and Quarmby 2019), and with a time lag in the education sector (Baek and Steiner-Khamisi 2024; Grek and Ydesen 2021; Rycroft-Smith 2022). Sector-specific features exist regarding why, how, and when research evidence is mobilised to justify policy decisions (Neal, Posner, and Brutzman 2021). In the education sector, the institutions and individuals involved in producing or brokering knowledge are likely to do so under conditions of ambiguity, contestation, and uncertainty.

Zahariadis' (2017, 65) observation concerning John Kingdon's multiple streams approach also applies to most other theories of the policy process: the need to find a lens, perspective, or framework 'that explains how national governments make policies under conditions of ambiguity.' The concept of ambiguity captures the 'state of having many ways of thinking about the same circumstances or phenomena' (Feldman 1989, 5; cited in Zahariadis 2017, 66). These different ways of thinking are not necessarily reconcilable, forcing those who govern – the 'government' broadly conceived – to make

choices. It would be wrong to assume that more knowledge reduces ambiguity and facilitates evidence-informed policymaking. The opposite applies. Today's information overload constitutes fertile ground for the flourishing of individuals and institutions that selectively draw on research, transform research findings into evidence, and then translate that evidence for policy use. The research question for policymaking under ambiguity becomes: How do policy brokers convince their users (policymakers) that they know the universe of 'ways of thinking' from which they draw conclusions and make recommendations? As has been explained by several authors (Espeland 2015; Martens and Niemann 2013; Mennicken and Espeland 2019), numbers rather than narratives are better positioned to scaffold evidence-informed policymaking with the 'façade of rationality, precision, and universality' (Steiner-Khamsi 2013, 21). Policymakers are enamored with numbers because numbers 'evoke narratives' and, therefore, enable them to interpret the numbers, that is, tell 'stories about what the indicators mean' (Espeland 2015, 65) from their own political perspective.

While ambiguity is an ecological feature of all public policies, contestation is especially pronounced in the education sector. Unlike the health sector, for example, every person in education, including those being educated, has a strong opinion of what good education entails. The 'democratisation of expertise' (Maasen and Weingart 2005) is widespread in education – everyone thinks they are education experts – but almost absent, for example, in the health sector, as reflected in the technologies of exclusion (e.g. medical jargon or certification of expertise). Research evidence in education is traceable and intelligible for everyone and is therefore also a matter of public opinion and, as a corollary, a terrain of public contestation. The consequences for knowledge brokerage are far-reaching: the intermediaries between science and politics need to make a case for why *their* expertise is (more) impartial than that of other brokers. Applied to policy brokerage, the question is how credibility in the knowledge source is established. A dilemma complicates the issue. On the one hand, governments would like to rely on experts with insider knowledge who are sufficiently familiar with the bureaucracy to provide valuable and realistic advice regarding complex matters. On the other hand, the most credible experts are independent experts, preferably academics working outside the bureaucracy (see Boswell 2017). Since the same person is rarely able to inhabit both spaces, a hierarchisation of evidence and knowledge sources comes into play, such as with randomised controlled trials as the gold standard or the OECD as a trusted knowledge source in education policy.

Lastly, the education sector is prone to uncertainty because it claims to prepare its objects – the ones being educated – for the future (Hansen, Sivesind, and Thøstrup 2021). If we conceive of technology as the device that turns inputs into desired outcomes, the 'technology deficit of education' (Luhmann and Schorr 1979) becomes glaring. The assumed causal link – being educated increases the ability to cope in the future – may only be assessed in the future and thus eludes an empirical investigation in the present. This third feature also has vast repercussions for policy brokerage: the future must be presented as a logical extension of the precarious present so that actions can be taken in the present to avert the projected negative future (Robertson and Beech 2023). The long list of 'actionable research evidence' may be understood against the backdrop that the belief in practical actions in the present helps

to reduce, or at least manage, the sense of uncertainty produced by an unpredictable future.

2. The commitment to multi-disciplinarity and methodological transnationalism

The sector-specific challenges – ambiguity, contestation, and uncertainty – which are endemic to policymaking in education, call for the confluence of several interpretive frameworks. There is agreement that the study of public policy is a multidisciplinary endeavour that draws on several disciplines, fields, and methods of inquiry (Weible and Workman 2022). In this article, we combine three lenses with their respective methods of inquiry: a historical lens that enables us to trace the rise of the global education governing complex over the last five decades, a political science lens that focuses on instruments of global governance, and a policy studies lens that sheds light on why and when global policies resonate, how they are selectively borrowed, and then locally adapted and recontextualised in the ‘transfer space’ (Porto de Oliveira and Osorio Gonnet 2023, 369).

The transnational nature of this study deserves special mention here. Rather than viewing a government as a homogenous entity that functions in a spatially bounded national system, we adopt the notion of network governance and disaggregate government by scale (national, regional, global), by function (advisory, executive, and legislative bodies), and as public versus private entities. Arguably, policy studies are prone to fall into the trap of ‘methodological nationalism’ (Wimmer and Glick Schiller 2003), given the preoccupation with the nation-state. The methodological bias also applies to studies that reflect the international dimension but see the national relationship with the global as ‘hierarchical, linear and hegemonic’ (Grek 2020, 175).

Given our affinity with comparative policy studies, we are not prepared to dismiss the notions of ‘national’ and ‘global’ entities because the nexus between the two units of analysis explains, to some extent, the policymaking of (national) governments. We conceive of the national and the global as interdependent spaces rather than distinct places. For this reason, we do not view the ‘global’ as ‘external’ to national policymaking (Gulson et al. 2023; Hartong and Nikolai 2017). We found that policy actors at particular moments of protracted policy constellations tend to instrumentally mobilise global actors *as if* they were external political forces (Steiner-Khamisi 2021; Steiner-Khamisi and Waldow 2012). Our focus on the relational aspect between the global and national levels of government is very much in line with Stone’s (2020, 7) encouragement to unabashedly commit to ‘methodological transnationalism.’ Such a methodological approach is genuine in comparative policy analysis, which in turn ‘is the DNA of policy transfer studies’ (Porto de Oliveira and Osorio Gonnet 2023, 368).

2.1. The rise of the OECD and the World Bank as the first movers in policy brokerage

Any historical inquiry attempting to reconstruct the trajectory of international organisations (IOs) growing into policy brokers needs to start with the founding years of the IOs, followed by a closer scrutiny of the Cold War and postcolonial periods. A key objective of the Western bloc and the United States, in particular, was to minimise Soviet influence.

Unlike the communist bloc, which was united by employing political ideology, the strategy of the West was to have coordinating and norm-setting international bodies in place that provided a sense of cohesion and propelled collaboration between the member states. In that sense, the Organisation for European Economic Co-operation (OEEC), renamed in 1961 as the OECD, functioned very much as an ‘economic NATO’, as poignantly remarked by Leimgruber and Schmelzer (2017).

In 1957, the Sputnik shock sparked an interest in school systems as the deliverer of engineers and technical personnel. It generated momentum for the OEEC, and later for the OECD, to reposition itself as a herald for world-class education (Papadopoulos 1994; Ydesen and Grek 2019). In the wake of this repositioning, the organisation poured considerable resources into developing education statistics and figuring out how education could be optimised by utilizing more effective planning, drawing on cybernetics and human capital theory (Popkewitz 2022). Mimicking the multi-year plans of the communist world, the OECD’s manpower planning in the 1960s and early 1970s was relatively technocratic and preoccupied with forecasting labour market needs. Over time, the development of indicators, and eventually benchmarks, took on a life of their own. International comparison or, more broadly speaking, metrics became the hallmark of the OECD. As Seitzer, Baek, and Steiner-Khamsi (2023) pointed out, the quantification enterprise of the OECD became unstoppable. According to Jarl Bengtsson, a former head and long-time staff member (1971–2002) of the OECD’s Centre for Educational Research and Innovation, the 1980s were the time when the center started to develop its ‘strong focus on educational standards and interest in indicators’ (Bengtsson 2008, 2), which led to its International Education Indicators programme, the *Education at a Glance* series, and finally PISA (Grek and Ydesen 2021).

The Cold War also had significant repercussions for countries in the Global South. In the post-colonial period of the 1960s and 1970s, the World Bank supported its member countries in their race against the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR) and its Council for Mutual Economic Assistance (CMEA), seeking to win over non-aligned countries in the Global South (Westad 2005). In addition to financial support for infrastructure, knowledge, and technology transfer, it enabled the two superpowers and their respective allies to stay involved or become involved in previously colonised countries. The development turn was for countries of the Global South what the quantification turn was for countries of the non-communist Global North. In the education sector, it was only from 1990 onwards, with the establishment of the first international agreement, Education for All (EFA), that countries of the Global South were subdued to the quantification regime of IOs. The new era of international agreements propelled the creation of an ever-growing number of international benchmarks coordinated by UNESCO, the UN’s specialised agency for education, and enforced first by the World Bank and later by all other IOs.

In the early years, the World Bank’s portfolio in education was almost identical to that of UNESCO. In stark contrast to the World Bank, however, UNESCO had a humanistic and human rights-driven approach to education. The connection between the two organisations was sealed through the Co-operative Agreement signed in 1964. After gaining access to countries of the Global South with the help of UNESCO, the World Bank started to distance itself from UNESCO. It became increasingly apparent that the two

organisations neither shared outlooks and priorities nor a *modus operandi* in governance. As pointed out by Elfert and Ydesen (2023):

[t]he World Bank's influence on education in developing countries derived from its funding power and claims to managerial-scientific efficiency, exemplified by its managerial tools, such as the highly bureaucratic lending cycle and the Poverty Reduction Strategy Papers. (Elfert and Ydesen 2023, 100)

Similar to the OECD, the World Bank invested in indicator development in the late 1980s. The organisation progressively expanded its databank from 116 indicators in April 1989 to 1,600 indicators in October 2018,² The path to knowledge brokerage was similar for both IOs. Each established a quantification apparatus that produced data-based policy analyses and disseminated their recommendations as research syntheses.

Signaling the advent of a new era in which both organisations were determined to work independently in education, the World Bank published its first Education Sector Policy Paper in April 1980 (World Bank 1980). According to prominent education economist George Psacharopoulos, who served as a long-time senior advisor at the World Bank:

[t]he 1980 Policy Paper does not only reflect the fact that Bank operations are now increasingly based on the results of research, but also that the Bank conducts research of its own and will continue to do so in the future. This is extremely welcome for the Bank has access to a wealth of comparative education material outsiders could not even dream about. (Psacharopoulos 1981, 144)

Arguably, the policy broker trajectories of the OECD and the World Bank were steeped in recurrent crisis narratives about the worldwide spread of the education crisis. Given their universal reach, the IOs heard the calling. Many US-spearheaded international conferences on education crises were held in the 1960s, such as the Bellagio meetings in 1960, which called on governments to adopt a human capital approach and expand their educational systems to boost growth; the 1961 OECD Policy Conference on Economic Growth and Investment in Education held in Washington D.C.; and the International Conference on the World Crisis in Education at Williamsburg, Virginia, in 1967 (Elfert and Ydesen 2023; see also Brehm 2023). Philip H. Coombs, the first Assistant Secretary of State for Education and Culture (appointed by President John F. Kennedy), the first Director of the UNESCO International Institute for Educational Planning, and author of the influential book *The World Education Crisis* (Coombs 1968), personified more than anyone else the universalist claim. Published in a divided world during the Cold War, Coombs' book was harshly criticised on the other side of the Iron Curtain (see Steiner-Khamsi 2006).

Nevertheless, the crisis scenario received yet another significant boost in the 1980s with the publication of the Reagan administration's *A Nation at Risk* report (National Commission on Excellence in Education 1983). The report depicted the American education system as a cause for concern and an obstacle to the country's economic growth and technological progress, especially when compared with Germany, Japan, and the Soviet Union. The report prompted the United States to push for the development of international comparative indicators. Eventually, this task fell on the OECD, which created the International Educational Indicators project in the late 1980s, thus instituting a comparative turn in global education policy. Cross-national comparison was seen as the best engine for advancing educational quality (Martens 2007). The governance by numbers modality did not fully evolve until the 1990s, with the publication of *Education*

at a Glance in 1992 and, at the turn of the millennium, with PISA and PISA-induced education knowledge outlets (e.g. Education Policy Outlook and Education GPS). Crisis scenarios became the norm rather than the exception and were periodically invoked whenever the results of international large-scale student assessments were released.

Under the presidency of Robert McNamara (1968–1981), the World Bank became a development agency with its own resources and expertise in education. Similar to the changes within the OECD, the 1990s may be characterised as the decade in which the World Bank ramped up its research activity in the education sector. The establishment of the Global Development Network in 1999 was an important milestone for the metamorphosis of the World Bank into a knowledge bank (Stone 2000). Initially meant to strengthen knowledge production at the country level – as opposed to knowledge production in the headquarters – to strengthen the use of research evidence for policy decisions, the Global Development Network lost its great promise and was eclipsed by numerous other centrally administered initiatives (such as the Systems Approach for Better Education Results (SABER) in the education sector). As before, the global databanks were designed at the headquarters, with national experts merely serving as informants and translators that helped populate the global databanks.

2.2. Policy brokerage as a global and regional governance tool

Arguably, policy brokerage enables non-state actors and international institutions to serve as backstage advisors in a domain traditionally reserved for the state. The shift from government to governance is commonly seen as the result of new public management policies that most OECD countries introduced in the wake of neoliberal reforms of the 1980s and 1990s, followed by countries in the Global South in the last two decades. In the education sector, this shift enabled IOs to take up a new role in developing policy instruments for generating or, consequently, alleviating reform pressure. The shift toward governance by numbers in the education sector accompanied a shift from input regulation to performance measurement, as epitomised in International Large-Scale Student Assessments (e.g. OECD's PISA or IEA's TIMSS) designed and delivered by IOs. Numbers became the primary language code between state and non-state entities and between IOs and governments.

Disaggregating the large group of IOs by sector reveals fascinating patterns: In 2020, 30 IOs explicitly addressed education policy as part of their policy portfolio, that is, 30 inter-governmental institutions with states as members and organisational structures dedicated to dealing with education as a field of activity (Niemann and Martens 2021). In particular, four observations of the growth of IOs in the field of education are worth mentioning here. First, the number of education IOs steadily grew from just two in 1945, namely the International Labour Organisation (ILO) and the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation (UNESCO), to 30 in 2020. Furthermore, there was no sharp increase in a particular decade but an incremental expansion from 1945 until the mid-1990s. A second observation, however, is that the expansion slowed down considerably toward the end of the 1990s, with only two education IOs founded after 2005. Ending a 40-year period of continuous growth, during which education was discovered as a significant field of IO activity, the stagnation at the end of the old millennium suggests a saturation of the field. Third, our findings suggest that over the past 60 years or so,

educational topics penetrated the portfolios of non-education IOs. Many IOs with no direct mandate for education policy started to engage in education-related matters from the late 1960s onwards. Their number increased to the extent that by the year 2023, a third of the entire population of IOs ($n = 30$) operating in part or entirely in the education sector consisted of IOs that were designed to coordinate international economic cooperation, such as the World Bank, the OECD, or the regional development banks. Education-for- mandates – such as education for economic growth, peace, international understanding, sustainable development, and a global knowledge economy – became the standard line of argumentation to fund and promote education activities in non-education IOs. Fourth, the development in the education IO population reflects intensified regionalism. While initially, it was mainly globally active IOs like UNESCO and the ILO that dealt with education policy, more and more IOs with a regional focus – such as ASEAN (Association of Southeast Asian Nations) or Caricom (Caribbean Community) – included education topics in their policy portfolios over time. Summarised in terms of global governance research, education-related matters have gained momentum at the global and regional levels, not only among organisations specializing in education but also among those advancing their own economic, ecological, social, and other agendas by employing educational programmes (Niemann and Martens 2021; Martens, Niemann, and Krogmann 2024), see Figure 1.

Most studies of global policy brokerage in education focus either on the OECD (often more narrowly of the OECD's PISA) or the World Bank. Without a doubt, these two IOs were the first movers in terms of data-driven policy brokerage (see Seitzer, Baek, and Steiner-Khamsi 2023). However, a comparative lens brings to light the diversity of

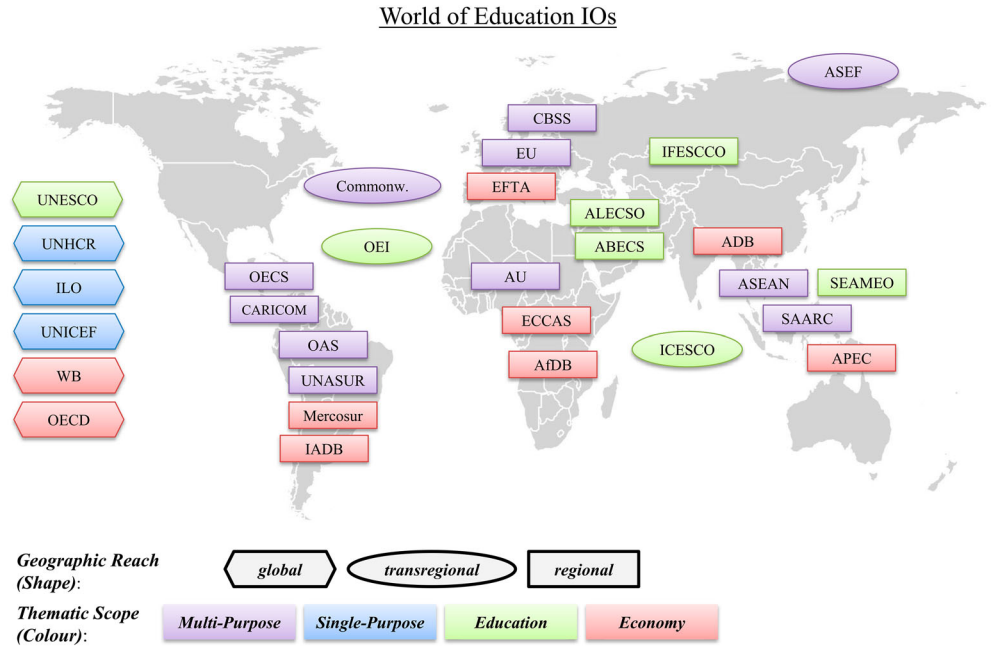


Figure 1 . The World of Intergovernmental Organisations. Source: Martens, Niemann, and Krogmann 2024, p. 485.

brokerage instruments: each IO bundles its primary knowledge brokerage instrument (in the case of OECD, mainly PISA, including its offspring products) with a different set of knowledge products, such as peer reviews (OECD), warehousing of good practices (World Bank), or peer exchange at the regional level (Global Partnership for Education), to name a few. Even though the IOs' language of brokerage is remarkably similar ('three takeaways', 'six insights', 'research suggests'), and their reliance on numerical data is unmissable, the IOs use different brokerage instruments and, as a corollary, purpose knowledge brokerage differently. A case in point is the lesson-drawing practice in policy brokerage. Drawing on data from the comprehensive World Education Reform Database (WERD)³, Seitzer, Baek, and Steiner-Khamsi (2023) found that OECD reports tend to reference experiences in other countries. By contrast, the World Bank reports tend to be self-referential in drawing their lessons, in that the reports reiterate their portfolio of best practices, as documented in their SABER programme.

Largely unexplored is the interdependency among IOs, such as how IOs respond to changes in the brokerage approach of other IOs. Do IOs mimic, divide and rule, or do they compete over policy brokerage? These and other relational research questions require an in-depth historical inquiry into the brokerage activities of several IOs, not just a comparison between the first two movers, the OECD and the World Bank. What exactly does the race over global norm setting and policy impact entail for IOs? Is it about identifying new, untapped thematic priorities, such as social-emotional learning (first promoted by UNICEF, and now also by OECD and UNESCO), increasing impact, and in some instances financial resources, by establishing partnerships with civil society (e.g. Basic Education Coalitions), EDU businesses and philanthropic foundations? Is it about strengthening ties with governments by instating intermediaries at the regional level (e.g. four regional hubs of the Global Partnership for Education's Knowledge and Innovation Exchange (GPE KIX)), or is it about building coalitions with some but not with other IOs? Despite rhetorical affirmations to the contrary, a preliminary assessment seems to suggest that the five main IOs in education (GPE⁴, OECD, UNESCO, UNICEF, and the World Bank) have increased their competition over the past few years, in part because the IOs now also compete over the same funds of private foundations (Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, Hewlett Packard Foundation, Master Card Foundation, Lego Foundation, Porticus Foundation, and others). With the OECD's PISA expansion into non-OECD partner countries, these IOs now operate in great part in the same countries.

Ironically, the features of the digital economy in an era of mass manufacturing of information set up the stage for a constellation that at first seems contradictory: Even if IOs compete with each other, they depend on networking and sharing data to build large data banks and reach large audiences. Websites or digital platforms are one of the most common communication tools for policy brokerage, other tools are meetings, visits, conferences, and so forth, often co-sponsored by several IOs. Digital platforms rely on members outside their organisation and networks to attract users. Digital platforms are an asset for organisations in other ways, too: even though most of the information on the platforms is made freely available, organisations appropriate value through ownership of certain services (technical assistance, workshops, courses, and so forth) and control rights (Birch and Muniesa 2020). There also exist indirect benefits, such as expanding the organisation's reach and impact by networking with other organisations with which they entertain weak ties – that is, organisations that work in the same

policy domain but in adjacent fields, other countries, or other areas of expertise (Weber and Yanovitzky 2021). As a result, there is a surge in coalition building and networking activities among some IOs at the exclusion of others, such as in the Building Evidence in Education (BE2) (World Bank Group, FCDO, USAID, and one rotating UN agency) or the Learning Data Compact (UNESCO, UNICEF, World Bank).

2.3. Brokering along the policy cycle

Although studies on global governance have examined what global actors do and which instruments they apply to exert influence, comparative policy studies have investigated, as mentioned before, the local/national/regional encounters with global actors, their agendas, and their instruments. Rather than assuming that governments are helpless victims or passive recipients of policy advice transferred from the global to the national level, research on policy transfer, global policy studies, policy mobility, or policy borrowing – terms that are frequently used interchangeably in comparative policy studies in education – examines the features of the transfer space to understand the global/national nexus. As a result, the scrutiny of reception, resistance, translation, and projection processes, and more precisely, the politics and economics of these processes, are at the center stage of this particular body of research (Morais de Sá e Silva 2017; Steiner-Khamisi and Waldow 2012). The two varied disciplinary lenses – what IOs do and how governments respond – complement each other.

In particular, the externalisation thesis and the notion of reference societies are relevant to this study (see Schriewer 1990). As with other notions of sociological systems theory, the ecological perspective is also manifested in the externalisation thesis. Changes in other systems – such as the neoliberal move to results-based regulation in public administration – are effective only if they resonate, are rendered meaningful, and are translated into the logic and language code of the system. In the system of education, results-based regulation was translated into a shift from teaching to learning (Fenwick, Mangez, and Ozga 2014), a move that ultimately resulted in a ‘datafication’ of learning (Thoutenhoofd 2018). In the language of systems theory, the system’s ‘internal construction of external points of reference’ (Mangez and Vanden Broeck 2020) generates additional meaning, helps reproduce its identity, and produces certainty. According to Luhmann (1995, 481), externalisation or the construction of such quasi-external points of reference serve as ‘regulative ideas’, which on closer examination are ‘projections’ that ‘are valid only “as if” they were valid.’ ‘Finnish success’ is a good case in point. A long list of explanations is given for why Finnish students do well on ILSAs. Depending on what the controversial policy issue is for which policy actors seek a (internally induced) quasi-external source of authority, Finland’s success is alternately attributed to its university-based solid teacher education system, its inclusive schooling with minimal tracking of students, or the nurturing environment in schools where students are ironically exposed to few high-stakes standardised tests. Focusing on the transfer space helps shed light on windows of change that precede policy transfer or, formulated in terms of sociological systems theory, on the timing at which quasi-external points of reference are mobilised for domestic policy decisions. Protracted policy conflicts, changes in the administration, breaking with an undesired past, reorientation in a new geopolitical space, and aid dependency are only some of the political

and economic reasons explored in policy borrowing research (Steiner-Khamsi and Waldow 2012).

Since the use of research evidence has become a constitutive element of the policy process, we may also dig deeper and ask when or at what stage in the policy process research evidence is mobilised. Do policymakers use different types of research evidence at different stages of the policy process? The question of procedural tools has preoccupied scholars in public policy studies in general (Bali et al. 2021) as well as those interested in investigating the use of research evidence at different policy process stages in particular (Ouimet et al. 2023). In comparative education policy studies, there is a tendency to focus on agenda setting and point out the salutary effects of international references, such as references to OECD knowledge products (in particular PISA-related products), for creating problem awareness, coalition building, and mobilizing financial resources for school reform. However, the architects of ILSAs desire to exert a much bigger impact than merely creating public uproars or celebrations every few years when the results are released. According to Schleicher, the chief architect of OECD's PISA, and his associates:

[T]he organisation [OECD] provides a unique forum and knowledge hub for data and analysis, exchange of experiences, best-practice sharing, and advice on public policies and international standard-setting. (Schleicher et al. 2021, 1)

The gross discrepancy between the supply and demand of research evidence for policy-making purposes has incited the imagination of policy brokers. Best and Holmes (2010) identified three generations of scholars who examined the knowledge-to-action (KTA) linkage and presented suggestions on how to tighten the association. The first was primarily concerned with research dissemination or, as mentioned in the beginning, how to better communicate or 'push' research evidence onto policymakers. The second generation pointed out the relational aspect between producers and users. They wrote up a host of recommendations on how to co-produce knowledge products with end users. The most recent group of studies procedurally breaks down the use of research evidence, investigates the capacity of using research evidence, and explores the eco-system necessary to produce and use data and research evidence for policy. For IOs, the underutilisation of their research evidence deposited on the web is a cause for concern. In recent years, this has prompted global actors to establish regional structures that facilitate webinars, peer exchange among policymakers, conferences, and other means of communicating and disseminating their research evidence more effectively.

The procedural approach that determines when and how research evidence is used in the policy process offers the possibility of disaggregating the various policy actors involved in the transfer space. For example, a five-country study (Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway, and Sweden) compared the body of research evidence used by government-appointed expert panels with the studies the Ministry of Education and Science cites in its decrees. Given the institutionalised form of knowledge brokerage in the form of government-appointed expert panels in Norway and Sweden, it was surprising to find that the respective Ministry of Education and Science selects very few publications mentioned in the reports of their expert panels but instead cites a different body of research to justify its policy decisions (Steiner-Khamsi et al. 2022). In the case of Norway, for example, of the 464 texts that the five relevant expert panels listed in the

reference sections of their reports, only 22 were also cited in the ministerial decrees. Furthermore, of the 22 sources cited, 20 were retrieved from the expert panel that was charged with reviewing the OECD's blueprint for competency-based curriculum reform, known as OECD's DeSeCo (Definition and Selection of Competencies) project. Not all commissioned reports of expert panels carry the same political weight. Despite the path dependency in policy advisory systems of the Nordic European region, the OECD is referenced more frequently than any other global, regional, or national policy broker and more frequently than influential individual authors such as John Hattie.

3. Conclusion

In this article, we have applied a multidisciplinary, transnational, and relational lens to examine how IOs have, over time, adopted policy brokerage as an instrument of global governance, how that instrument is put to work at various stages of the policy process, and how it is used in different policy contexts.

The historical perspective allowed us to investigate whether IOs have become similar or dissimilar in terms of policy brokerage styles and approaches. Considering the surplus of information, the question of how policy brokers operate in a crowded and contested terrain deserves greater attention. The short historical sketch presented in this article focuses on the two first movers in policy brokers, the OECD and the World Bank. Even though the World Bank and UNESCO cooperated closely from 1964 to 1980, the World Bank dropped UNESCO when it started to produce its own reports. The myriad of analyses of the rates of return of education to economic growth is a case in point to illustrate the applied policy research empire that the World Bank built over a long period. In their overview of 60 years of research on returns on investment in education, Psacharopoulos and Patrinos (2018) drew on a World Bank database with 1,120 rate-of-return estimates in 139 countries. Even though the OECD and the World Bank were the first movers, the science-politics linkage was also pursued by UNESCO and UNICEF, albeit with a considerable time lag. Even though policy brokerage looks remarkably similar in language and format, the sources for substantiating policy advice differ. The OECD, for example, tends to refer more to country-level experiences and reforms. By contrast, the World Bank has built its best policies and reforms portfolio based on randomised controlled trials and other inquiry forms. Thus, the IOs carved their niche for policy brokerage over time to demarcate their territory and extol their comparative advantage vis-à-vis other IOs.

The global governance perspective has brought to light the proliferation of global and regional intergovernmental organisations with a mandate in education. The growth occurred over five decades and reached a standstill at the turn of the millennium. Since then, education as a topic of global importance has expanded into multi-stakeholder organisations (e.g. Global Partnership for Education), private foundations (e.g. Gates Foundation), and international businesses (e.g. Pearson Inc.), reflecting public-private partnerships that spread worldwide like wildfire at all levels of public administration. Strikingly, education has become a field or a market, as reflected in non-education IOs (e.g. OECD, World Bank) and non-education businesses and philanthropies that reoriented themselves to integrate education as part of their mandate. Thus, the global education governing complex nowadays includes the Big Five in education, as well as private foundations and international businesses, either with a primary or secondary mandate in

education. Exerting soft power by hard facts has become the rule rather than the exception for all IOs. In education, the role of international large-scale student assessments, such as the OECD's PISA, should not be underestimated as a 'governing by numbers' (Grek, 2009), standard-setting, and performance-measurement policy tool. International comparison – and by implication, ranking, naming, and shaming – is now mainstreamed and utilised by all kinds of IOs (including international non-governmental organisations) and for all kinds of purposes (including advocacy). As observed by many and mentioned earlier, numerical comparative data are popular among decision-makers because they provoke the need for interpretation and are, therefore, malleable for political meaning-making.

Finally, policy transfer research helps to complicate the theorem roughly sketched above, notably the assertion that policy brokerage has become a prominent global governance tool in an era of a surplus of research evidence. A comparative policy analysis approach suggests digging deeper into a question that appears commonsensical and unspectacular at first sight: Do policymakers actually use all the policy advice bestowed upon them from IOs? More specifically, whose (policy) knowledge is used, at which stage in a policy process is the knowledge integrated, and how do policymakers use evidence-based policy advice? Given the reorientation in global governance instruments and the vast apparatus IOs built to execute policy brokerage at the global, regional, and national levels, the research question should be seen as something other than anathema. As shown previously, there needs to be more voluntary use of platforms, networks, and initiatives that actively promote the use of research evidence for policy and planning. Decision makers direct their attention to such platforms at particular moments in the policy process when they search for a (quasi-) external source of authorisation to justify ideological preferences, unpopular or controversial policy decisions, or simply reform content able to gain a majority in parliament. Even in states with an institutionalised form of policy brokerage – such as the government-appointed expert panels in Norway and Sweden – the executive body of government (Ministry of Education and Science) resorts to its evidence sources to justify its policy decisions. Evidence-based policy advice is rampant in the Nordic region of Europe if we consider it indicative of how many references advisors and expert panels make to published studies and reports. Nevertheless, the executive bodies of government do not necessarily listen to policy brokers – not even to what their own government-appointed IOs have published.

In this article, we attempted to outline the contours of a new research programme in comparative education: knowledge brokerage as a new instrument of global governance. The empirical studies in such a programme could be considered a sequel to studies that demonstrated how global actors produce, circulate, and use numbers. In the proposed 'Governance by Numbers 2.0' research programme, the attention is directed to how global actors – twenty or thirty years later – deal with the surplus of numbers and evidence as well as the proliferation of knowledge brokers (including prominently Pearson, McKinsey, Gates Foundation, etc.; see also Auld and Morris 2023) in the era of the digital economy.

Policy brokerage is not simply information reduction but cognitive and political reframing of information. An underexplored issue that awaits further empirical investigation is whether institutional knowledge brokers have diversified their knowledge sources over

time to establish credibility. Facing the perpetual risk of being suspected of political manipulation, the big challenge for policy brokerage is making their advice appear scientific rather than agenda-driven. How can a trusted knowledge broker stand out in a space crowded with other knowledge brokers? The ordeal is especially pronounced in education because policies are produced and brokered not only under conditions of ambiguity but also in the context of public contestation and uncertainty.

Notes

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2. See <https://datatopics.worldbank.org/world-development-indicators/stories/world-development-indicators-the-story.html>.
3. The database contains documents on 6,700 education policies in 147 countries, over the period 1960–2017 (Bromley et al. 2021, 2023).
4. Nominally, the GPE is not an IO (intergovernmental organisation) but rather a multi-stakeholder international organisation with representation from donor countries, recipient countries, civil society, business, and foundations. However, it is *de facto* very much donor driven and functions like an IO (see Menashy 2018).

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